up to them and improve her game. "There's a big responsibility now from both team and country. I intend to work hard so everyone feels proud," she says. "Good thing is my teammates support and motivate me, as ups and downs are part and parcel of the game." An integral part of the team, her goals include preparing for the Pro League and the Asia Cup this year as well win the Asian Games gold and finish on the podium for the World Cup next year.

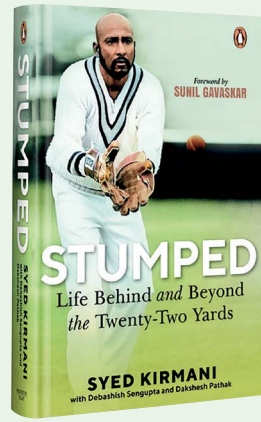
As the only girl in the extended family to take sport as a career, Deepika is grateful for her father's backing. She has "Laado" inked on her arm, her family's term of endearment for her. While there wasn't a Dangal-like standoff, there were questions over putting his only daughter into sport.



"There was no discrimination," she says. "He was like '*jo achchha lage tum karo*' [Do as you please]."

Deepika hopes that her exploits and those of her Haryanvi teammate and idol Savita Punia inspire more girls to pick up the stick. Says Deepika, "You can see a change in Haryana, there's rising interest and girls are being encouraged. But in some villages, the mindset still needs to change." Her rampage of goals may just do the trick. ■

–Suhani Singh



STUMPED
By Syed Kirmani
PENGUIN PLAY
Rs 499; 272 pages

BOOKS

A Gentleman *and His Game*

Stumped is Syed Kirmani's candid memoir of the highs and lows of a memorable cricketing career

The distinct shiny pate and the handlebar moustache; the resolute stand against Zimbabwe alongside Kapil Dev that kept India in the hunt at the 1983 World Cup. The long wait for his India debut, the baffling omissions during his prime, a forgettable Bollywood stint. And an unceremonious exit from the national team. The good and the bad featured in equal measure in Syed Kirmani's life. It's what makes his account in *Stumped*, co-authored by Debashish Sengupta and Dakshesh Pathak, an engrossing read.

An all-round athlete, Kirmani could have excelled at any sport. But cricket is what had his attention since the age of six, the youngest of the Jayamahal locality boys in Bangalore and so the default choice to stand behind the wickets. Those early lessons served him well and his progress was meteoric. In four years, he went from the Mysore state school team to feature in the Ranji Trophy, and three years later during the 1970–71 season, was picked for India.

A lesson in the art of patience followed. Each time he was picked here on, he sat on the sidelines as an understudy to the established Farokh Engineer. It took five long years after that initial selection for him to make his India debut.

Kirmani's final comeback after 1986 ended dismally. He persevered in domestic cricket till he was 45



And Kirmani was ready. He announced his arrival with a record to his name during his debut series against New Zealand. Here on, the middle-order batsman contributed with vital knocks and put on slick displays behind the stumps, equally at ease while keeping to the gifted spin quartet of Chandrasekhar, Bedi, Prasanna and Venkataraghavan, as to the raw pace of Kapil Dev.

For all his abilities, Kirmani was dropped from the Indian team time and again. After the high of the World Cup triumph, a final comeback in 1986 ended dismally following an 'injury' and he was sidelined for good. Kirmani remained hopeful and persevered on the domestic front until the age of 45, collecting the express deliveries of young guns like Javagal Srinath and David Johnson. Until one day, he just didn't feel the fight in him anymore and put away his gloves.

His farewell was as forgettable as his days as an administrator. While Kirmani regales with tales of his humble beginnings and of the mighty West Indies of the late 1970s and brings to life anecdotes from the Indian dressing room, there's a sense of despondency in the narrative on what might have been. And perhaps closure after making a clean breast of it all. ■

–Shail Desai